

MODC - Explores something unknown
~~explores~~ What Don't I know?

I stutter, I nod I try to understand.

The worlds at the dinner table fall like breadcrumbs,
half-formed, half-english thick with Afrikaans influence.
My grandmother sits opposite me, waxy hands folded.
I smile too much too wide say 'Ja Ja Ja' but
everything slips past, the vowels foreign, their tongue
too fast. They talk about the unknown, people I've
never met, places I've never been, time that I've
missed. The table stretches between us, like a
void.

My ~~wax~~ uncle chuckles "You still remember Ouma's
koebisters ne?" ~~unintelligible~~ unhelligable.

I thought I knew everything about myself,
but I've been accustomed to using my eyes for
only what's in front of me, only exploring myself
through how I look. ~~Myself~~ My mother has
returned to Durban south Africa for the first time
since leaving her absence not just distance but
resistance. She buried this history under layers of
assimilation leaving only the tip of ~~it explored~~
to be explored by me and hiding the rest underground.
And now we're here, her out of obligation, myself
out of curiosity.

Occasionally she make a soulless curry from a
jar. I grew up in our suburban apartment in
Marrickville ~~STP~~ Sydney with flat vowels and

and vegetable. ~~No milktert at Vethack.~~

Milktert and Vethack were hidden around the corner, unexplored.

My Grandmother places the Bunny Chow in front of me, "Eat". Thick spiced curry spilling from a hollowed loaf of white bread. The scent is familiar, warm, peppery, but much more. Even the smallest change made it have something in it that was unknown, this one tastes real, rougher and richer, non-westernised.

My Aunt, Lizeel begins a story, her 16th birthday. She'd dressed her best, only to be told she had to eat out back, while ~~any~~ my mother and grand father were welcomed inside. My mother, the fair-skinned child of a European, now estranged, father and a Black mother was chosen by the clan machine of racial privilege at birth. "You got to sit outside", Lizeel continues, a smile faltering on her face. It's a strange bitterness, almost lovely. A complicated word.

Then someone laughs and just like that the moment collapses. The table erupts in noise again pushing the memory out of sight. Voices overlapping, clashing, fighting to fill the silence that lingers like smoke. A job scene does to explain. I force out a chuckle, though my stomach churns. What don't I know?

~~The hollowed~~
I glance at my mother, but she is still a stranger here, just as I am. Her shoulders tense at the sound of her cultural name 'Tsalka' rolling from my grandmother's tongue. ~~She does not~~ She does not correct her, does not remind her that she's been ~~Tsa~~ Michelle for longer than this ever was Tsalka. She buried this history, kept on pushing it further and further into the fog, hoping it disappears.

The hollowed out bread has collapsed under the weight of the merris, crumbs and streaks of spice staining the table. The meal is gone, but ~~my~~ I remain empty. ^{I hunger,} Not ~~for~~ for food, but for fulfillment, to explore.

I want to ask, What Don't I know, What are all the little memories I've missed.

I try. I shape the words in my mouth, trying to force my tongue into something unfamiliar. "Well but eh genius." The words are clumsy, butchered with accent, but I must find it, find the part of myself that is unexplored. What don't I know.

Here at this table, I sit ~~thoroughly~~ hungry, between crumbs and the echoes of laughter I yearn to ~~find~~ find the unknown.

b) My creative, What I Don't I know, explores on a protagonist's first encounter with his African family, where an anecdote of a apartheid struggle sparks his inquiry into his inherited silence, when his cultural history becomes an unknown that he wishes to explore. ~~Story~~ Storytelling is central with place developed around a shared meal of bunny chow symbolising cultural displacement, inherited silence and fractured identity, leaving the protagonist with a fragmented sense of self, where he wishes to explore his unknown cultural history. Inspired by Nam He's love and Honour, I adopt his cultural settings and non-linear narrative to highlight the inherited silence's role in shaping identity.

In crafting my setting, I sought to emulate Nam He's immersive evocation of a place, where the environment becomes a tactile extension of memory and identity that ~~the~~ is ~~protagonist~~ unknown to the protagonist. Just as ~~Nam He's~~ protagonist sits on the periphery of a chaotic sensory rich Vietnamese gathering that he is unable to reach, "A thicket of Vietnamese voices crossing, leaping..." My own creative piece situates the protagonist in a similar cultural unknown, where the setting subtly cues his dislocation and inherited silence. The simile in the line "The table stretches between us like an ocean of separation" transforming an everyday domestic space into a symbol of the unknown through the protagonist's emotional and cultural distance. Likewise the moment "Not held et genius" uses the Afrikaners as a symbol of the protagonist

b) entering the unknown cultural space and
exploring it. Through this, setting acts as more
than just a backdrop; it becomes the physical space
where memory, trauma and identity intersect, allowing
the protagonist to explore them.